feel like a place where closeness and relationships with people need to have boundaries with enough of my own space carved in.

I'm not the only one, it turns out, that is suspicious of Bawden to begin with. Graeme Swann says, not too long after, that Bawden was like a lottery winner who got to spend six months around the England cricket team for no reason whatsoever. A lot of people move in and out of the dressing room – players and staff – and I have become used to seeing them pass through, occasionally promising the world to begin with, while I dig my heels into the surroundings and do what I can to both thrive and survive.

Six months later, true to his word, Bawden comes back to me. I have begun to get the sense from him that maybe he is not there for his own reasons, that maybe he does want what's best for the team and genuinely feels like he can provide it. I let him in, just a touch. Over a meeting, he does what he calls 'personality profiling', where he asks a series of questions. His observations, when he comes back with the results, are that I am an incredibly introverted and contained person, but on the field, I am, in his own words, like an explosive, aggressive machine. He identifies that maybe I lack some confidence but am also very emotional. He wouldn't want to get rid of the emotion, he says, calling it one of my super strengths, but we need to learn to channel it, so it doesn't become a weakness. At the moment, he continues gently, it feels like the situation determines my emotion – what is going on in the game, a decision by an umpire, what a batter has just said – rather than my own head. If we bring it under control, he suggests, I will be harnessing an absolute super strength.

Before we get any deeper, sensing that I'm not going to entertain sitting down and having therapeutic conversations, he simply suggests that I try and centre myself with breathing on the field. It's five breaths in and five breaths out, at the top of my mark. Once you get emotional, he explains, your breathing becomes really irregular, which sends messages about a deregulation of emotion to your brain, making it harder for you to manage it. I can teach myself a consistent heart rate apparently, send a signal to my brain that provides some calmness. When I feel the ball in my hand, he says, especially if I am worked up, just try and breathe in for five and then out for five again, with the sensation of the ball in my fingers. We don't talk any longer about it but, over the course of the summer, at first sceptical, I